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DYNAMICALLY GENERATING A REUSABLE PROCESS MODEL OBJECT FOR A WORKFLOW INCLUDING MULTIPLE CONDITIONS AND MULTIPLE ACTIONS

Abstract

A method for dynamically generating process model objects for workflows includes: obtaining a request from a user of a software application for configuring workflows, the request being for an initial workflow including multiple conditions and multiple actions, the request including user-provided information for one or more of the multiple conditions and one or more of the multiple actions; mapping the initial workflow to a template for generating process model objects for workflows, the template comprising a single condition block to represent the multiple conditions and a single action block to represent the multiple actions; extracting the user-provided information from the request; and dynamically generating a process model object for the initial workflow based, at least in part, on the extracted user-provided information and information associated with the template.

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Background/Summary

INTRODUCTION

[0001] Aspects of the present disclosure relate to dynamically generating a process model object for a requested workflow having multiple conditions and multiple actions and then reusing the process model object when the same or similar workflow request is received in the future.

BACKGROUND

[0002] Every year millions of people around the world utilize software applications to assist with countless aspects of life. Many software applications allow users to configure workflows by which certain actions are taken under certain conditions. For example, a software application may provide automation functionality, and a user may configure such automation functionality by specifying conditions under which automated actions are to be performed.

[0003] Software applications for configuring and automating workflows support single condition, single action workflows as these workflows can, given their defined structure, be represented by a static file. However, such software applications cannot support workflows having multiple conditions and multiple actions because, unlike single condition single action workflows, workflows having multiple conditions and multiple actions do not have a defined structure and therefore cannot be represented by a static file. Furthermore, given the large volume (e.g., in the thousands) of unique complex workflows that can be requested by a user, storing and maintaining a file for every possible multi-condition, multi-action workflow is not feasible.

[0004] Therefore, there is a need for improved techniques in such software applications to support workflows having multiple conditions and multiple actions.

BRIEF SUMMARY

[0005] Aspects and advantages of embodiments of the present disclosure will be set forth in part in the following description, or may be learned from the description, or may be learned through practice of the embodiments.

[0006] A method for dynamically generating process model objects for workflows includes: obtaining a request from a user of a software application for configuring workflows, the request being for an initial workflow including multiple conditions and multiple actions, the request including user-provided information for one or more of the multiple conditions and one or more of the multiple actions; mapping the initial workflow to a template for generating process model objects for workflows, the template comprising a single condition block to represent the multiple conditions and a single action block to represent the multiple actions; extracting the user-provided information from the request; and dynamically generating a process model object for the initial workflow based, at least in part, on the extracted user-provided information and information associated with the template.

[0007] Further embodiments include a non-transitory computer-readable storage medium storing instructions that, when executed by a computer system, cause the computer system to perform the method set forth above. Further embodiments include a system comprising at least one memory and at least one processor configured to perform the method set forth above.

[0008] The following description and the related drawings set forth in detail certain illustrative features of one or more embodiments.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0009] The appended figures depict certain aspects of the one or more embodiments and are therefore not to be considered limiting of the scope of this disclosure.

[0010] FIG. 1 depicts an example computing environment including components related to dynamically generating a process model object for workflows including multiple conditions and multiple actions according to some embodiments of the present disclosure.

[0011] FIG. 2 depicts an example user interface relating to creating a workflow including multiple conditions and multiple actions according to some embodiments of the present disclosure.

[0012] FIG. 3 depicts a template for dynamically generating process model objects for requested workflows including multiple conditions and multiple actions according to some embodiments of the present disclosure.

[0013] FIG. 4 depicts a dynamically generated process model object for a workflow including multiple conditions and multiple actions according to some embodiments of the present disclosure.

[0014] FIG. 5 depicts a structure of a dynamically generated process model object for a complex workflow of a first type according to some embodiments of the present disclosure.

[0015] FIG. 6 depicts a method for dynamically generating a process model object for a requested workflow including multiple conditions and multiple actions according to some embodiments of the present disclosure.

[0016] FIGS. 7A and 7B depict example processing systems related to dynamically generating a process model object for workflows including multiple conditions and multiple actions according to embodiments of the present disclosure.

[0017] To facilitate understanding, identical reference numerals have been used, where possible, to designate identical elements that are common to the drawings. It is contemplated that elements and features of one embodiment may be beneficially incorporated in other embodiments without further recitation.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

[0018] Aspects of the present disclosure relate to dynamically generating a process model for a multi-condition, multi-action workflow requested in a software application and reusing the process model object when another multi-condition, multi-action workflow is requested in the software application.

[0019] Creating a workflow in a software application allows a user to automate processes and solve use cases (e.g., approvals, reminders, notifications) according to user-specified rules. Files for created workflows may be maintained on a data store (e.g., database). The files for a created workflow include a process model object and a decision model object. In some embodiments, a process model object may refer to a business process model and notation (BPMN) object or another similar object that maps action identifiers to details that allow the actions to be performed. A decision model object may refer to a decision model and notation (DMN) object or another similar object that specifies conditions and actions of a workflow in a sequential manner. However, given the large number (e.g., in the thousands) of multi-condition, multi-action workflows that a user can create, creating and storing a static file for every possible multi-condition, multi-action workflow, especially the process model object associated with a given multi-condition, multi-action workflow, that may be requested by a user is not feasible.

[0020] Embodiments of the present disclosure overcome this problem with multi-condition, multi-action workflows. In particular, embodiments of the present disclosure are directed to techniques in which a process model object for a requested multi-condition, multi-action workflow is dynamically generated. For example, the process model object may be dynamically generated at runtime (e.g., in real-time as the multi-condition, multi-action workflow is being requested by a user of a software application for configuring workflows) using a template (e.g., base process model object) for generating process model objects for requested multi-condition, multi-action

workflows.

[0021] The template may, for example, include a single condition element or block to which the multiple conditions of the requested workflow may be mapped. The template may also include a single action element or block to which the multiple actions of the requested workflow may be mapped. The template may also include implicit information that needs to be included in every process model generated for multi-condition, multi-action workflows. For example, the implicit information may include an action that may not be included in the requested complex workflow but needs to be included in every process model object that is dynamically generated using the template.

[0022] To dynamically generate a process model object for a requested multi-condition, multi-action workflow, user-provided information (e.g., task name, email, etc.) that is extracted from configuration data associated with the requested multi-condition, multi-action workflow may be superimposed (e.g., merged) with the implicit information included in the template to dynamically generate (e.g., at run-time) the process model object for the requested multi-condition, multi-action workflow. In this manner, software applications for configuring workflows according to embodiments of the present disclosure are capable of generating multi-condition, multi-action workflows on the fly (e.g., at run-time) and are therefore improved compared to conventional software applications for configuring single-condition, single-action workflows based on static files generated for such single-condition, single-action workflows prior to run-time.

[0023] In addition to dynamically generating the process model object, a decision model object may be dynamically generated for the requested complex workflow as well. For instance, a source file for the decision model object specifying conditions and actions of the requested multi-condition, multi-action workflow in a sequential manner may be dynamically generated. Furthermore, the source file (e.g., extensible markup language file) for the decision model object may be stored on the data store.

[0024] Once generated, the process model object may be checked against a data store to determine if there is already an instance of the process model object saved on the data store. However, saving the source file (e.g., which may be an extensible markup language file) of the process model object is not preferable since the source file includes the user-specific information that would not be relevant if the generated process model object were reused for another multi-condition, multi-action workflow requested by another user. Also, querying the data store for the source file of the process model object is not performant if the source file is stored in its entirety, as searching for a length extensible markup language (XML) string is inefficient and requires large amounts of computing resources.

[0025] Embodiments of the present disclosure overcome this problem by generating data that is indicative of the process model object and, in particular, a structure (e.g., skeleton, tree, etc.) of the process model object indicating the relationship between the multiple conditions and multiple actions included in the requested workflow. For example, the structure of the dynamically generated process model object may include a plurality of nodes, and each of the nodes may correspond to a respective event included in a sequence of events to be performed based, at least in part, on the multiple conditions and the multiple actions included in the requested workflow. Furthermore, user-provided information for the requested workflow may be excluded from the structure of the process model object. In this manner, the structure of the process model object may be immune to changes to properties (e.g., values, conditions, sequences of nodes) of the dynamically generated process model object and therefore is representative of the core structure of the process model object.

[0026] In some embodiments, the structure of the process model object may be represented as an adjacency vector or list representing properties (e.g., activity identifier, type of element, existence of child nodes, etc.) of the different nodes included in the structure. The adjacency vector or list may be searched for in the data store to determine if there is already an instance of the adjacency

vector or list stored in the data store. If the adjacency vector or list is not already stored in the data store, the adjacency vector or list may, for example, be serialized and converted to a unique hash value that is then saved to the data store. In this manner, the data store may be queried (e.g., searched) for the adjacency vector or list (that is, the structure of the dynamically generated process model object) in a more efficient manner and reused for other multi-condition, multi-action workflows being requested in the software application. More particularly, the structure of the dynamically generated process model object may be reused for another multi-condition, multi-action workflow having the same or similar structure.

[0027] Techniques described herein provide multiple technical improvements over existing techniques for implementing configurable workflows in software applications. For example, by dynamically generating a process model object for a requested multi-condition, multi-action workflow and saving the structure of the dynamically generated process model object to a data store so that the structure of the dynamically generated process model object may be reused to create a subsequently requested multi-condition, multi-action workflow having the same structure (e.g., skeleton), techniques disclosed herein allow complex workflows to be configured and executed in a scalable manner that could not previously be achieved.

[0028] Furthermore, by saving data indicative of the structure of the process model object as opposed to the source file for the process model object, techniques disclosed herein utilize computational resources in a more efficient manner as the database can be queried in a more efficient manner as the data indicative of the unique structure of the process model object can be retrieved from the database more efficiently than a full previously-generated process model object (e.g., which is a larger file that would contain data that is irrelevant to subsequently requested multi-condition, multi-action workflows). Additionally, storing the data indicative of the unique structure of the process model object in a serialized form (e.g., as a unique hash value) in the database allows the database to be queried for an index column more efficiently than if the data were stored in a different form (e.g., in the form of a full process model object), thereby reducing computing resource utilization and improving the functioning of the computing devices involved.

Example Computing Environment for Automated Workflow Configuration

[0029] FIG. 1 illustrates an example computing environment **100** for automated workflow configuration according to embodiments of the present disclosure.

[0030] The computing environment **100** includes a server **120** and a client **130** connected over a network **110**. The network **110** may be representative of any type of connection over which data may be transmitted, such as a wide area network (WAN), local area network (LAN), cellular data network, and/or the like.

[0031] The server **120** includes an application **122**, which generally represents a computing application that users interact with over the network **110**, such as via computing devices (e.g., a user may interact with application **122** via client **130**). In some embodiments, the application **122** is accessed via a user interface associated with the client **130**.

[0032] In some embodiments, the application **122** is an electronic financial accounting system that assists users in book-keeping or other financial accounting practices. Additionally, or alternatively, the financial management system can manage one or more of tax return preparation, banking, investments, loans, credit cards, real estate investments, retirement planning, bill pay, and budgeting. In such embodiments, workflows described herein may relate to automatically performing actions (e.g., prompting a particular individual for approval) upon the occurrence of certain conditions related to financial management (e.g., when an invoice is created within the software application that has an amount over a threshold). In other embodiments, the application **122** provides other, non-financial functionality, and involves workflows that do not necessarily relate to finances. Generally, the application **122** allows users to configure workflows in which particular actions are automatically performed upon the occurrence of particular conditions. Workflows may also relate to filtering or searching through a data set, such as specifying

conditions (e.g., nested or otherwise) under which results should be displayed. The application **122** can be a standalone system, or can be integrated with other software or service products provided by a service provider.

[0033] The data store **140** generally represents a data storage entity such as a database or repository that stores data relating to the application **122** and/or a workflow processing engine **124**, including data **142** that is indicative of the structure of different process model objects dynamically generated for different multi-condition, multi-action workflows. For example, the data **142** may include first data indicative of a unique structure for a first process model object dynamically generated for a first multi-condition, multi-action workflow. The data **142** may further include second data indicative of a unique structure for a second process model object dynamically generated for a second multi-condition, multi-action workflow. As will be discussed later on in more detail, the data **142** may be used to facilitate reusing the process model objects for subsequently requested multi-condition, multi-action workflows having the same structure.

[0034] The workflow processing engine **124** generally provides functionality related to dynamically assisting with workflow configuration, such as performing validation on workflow configuration data and generating configuration recommendations as appropriate. While shown separately, some or all of the functionality described herein with respect to the workflow processing engine **124** may alternatively be part of the application **122** and/or may be implemented by one or more additional components.

[0035] In an example, as described in more detail below with respect to FIG. 2, a user may interact with a user interface (e.g., via the client **130**) in order to configure a multi-condition, multi-action workflow for the application **122**, and the resulting configuration data **152** for the multi-condition, multi-action workflow may be provided to the server **120**. The configuration data **152** may specify multiple conditions and multiple actions associated with the complex workflow. It is noted that configuration data **152** may include all or part of a workflow configuration. For example, the configuration data **152** may represent an intermediate state of a workflow configuration that is processed for validation before the workflow is further configured.

[0036] The workflow processing engine **124** may then perform an efficient validation of the configuration data **152** and, if a configuration issue is detected, may generate a configuration alert and/or recommendation **154** (e.g., indicating the configuration issue and/or recommending one or more correct configuration values).

[0037] A configuration alert and/or recommendation **154** may be provided to the user via the user interface (e.g., the configuration alert and/or recommendation **154** may be sent to client **130** and displayed via the user interface on the client **130**). An example of a configuration alert and/or recommendation **154** is described below with respect to FIG. 2.

Example User Interface Screen for Configuring a Multi-Condition Multi-Action Workflow

[0038] FIG. 2 illustrates an example user interface screen **200** related to configuring a multi-condition, multi-action workflow according to some embodiments of the present disclosure. For example, the user interface screen **200** may represent a screen of the application **122** of FIG. 1 accessed via a user interface displayed on the client **130** of FIG. 1. Generally, the user interface screen **200** provides user interface controls by which a user is enabled to configure the multi-condition, multi-action workflow. In an example, the user interface screen **200** provides drag and drop functionality, such as allowing a user to drag condition elements and action elements (e.g., from a list or section of the user interface that is not shown) onto a canvas, or otherwise allows the user to specify conditions, actions, and relationships between such conditions and actions.

[0039] In the depicted example, a workflow start event **202** has been configured, indicating that the complex workflow begins when an invoice is created or edited. Following the workflow start event **202**, a first condition **204** has been configured indicating an invoice amount between 0 and 100, and a “yes” path and “no” path for the first condition **204** are defined. The yes path for the first condition **204** indicates how the multi-condition, multi-action workflow should proceed when the

first condition **204** is satisfied (e.g., when an invoice amount is between 0 and 100). Conversely, the no path for the first condition **204** indicates how the multi-condition, multi-action workflow should proceed when the first condition **204** is not satisfied (e.g., when an invoice amount is not between 0 and 100).

[0040] For the yes path of the first condition **204**, a first action **206** has been configured, indicating that approval should be requested from a particular individual (Elizabeth Lane). The first action **206** is followed in the multi-condition, multi-action workflow by a first stop action **208**, indicating that the multi-condition, multi-action workflow ends. In alternative configurations (not shown), an action could be followed by another action or condition.

[0041] For the no path of the first condition **204**, a second condition **220** is currently being configured in the depicted example. Via controls **222**, **224**, **226**, and **228**, the user has selected that an invoice amount should be between 200.00 and 500.00. Controls **230** and **232** also allow the user to, respectively, delete or save the second condition **220**.

[0042] The no path for the second condition **220** includes a second action **236**, indicating that approval should be requested from a particular individual (Benedict John). The second action **236** is followed in the workflow by a second stop action **240**, indicating that the multi-condition, multi-action workflow ends.

[0043] The yes path for the second condition **220** includes a third condition **234**, which indicates an invoice amount between 200 and 300. The yes path for the third condition **234** includes an action, indicating that approval should be requested from a particular individual (Martin Gerard). A third action **242** is followed in the multi-condition, multi-action workflow by a third stop action **244**, indicating that the multi-condition, multi-action workflow ends. The no path for the third condition **234** includes a fourth action **246**, indicating that approval should be requested from a particular individual (Daniel Shelby). Action **236** is followed in the multi-condition, multi-action workflow by a stop action **248**, indicating that the workflow ends.

[0044] According to embodiments described herein, a process model object for the multi-condition, multi-action workflow may be dynamically generated. An example of the dynamically generated process model object is described below with respect to FIG. 4. Data indicative of a structure (e.g., skeleton) of the dynamically generated process model object may then be stored in a data store (such as the data store **140** in FIG. 1). In this manner, the process model object may be reused for subsequently created multi-condition, multi-action workflows having the same structure as the multi-condition, multi-action workflow illustrated in FIG. 2.

[0045] It is noted that user interface screen **200** is included as an example, and other types of user interface screens and/or methods of receiving workflow configuration data may alternatively be employed using techniques described herein.

Example Template for Dynamically Generating Process Model Objects for Multi-Condition Multi-Action Workflows

[0046] FIG. 3 illustrates a template **300** (e.g., base process model object) that may be used to dynamically generate process model objects for multi-condition, multi-action workflows according to some embodiments of the present disclosure. The template **300** may be used to dynamically generate a process model object for a multi-condition, multi-action workflow of a given type (e.g., approval workflow) and being requested in a software application. For simplicity, the template **300** will be discussed in the context of the multi-condition, multi-action workflow being requested via the user interface screen **200** illustrated in FIG. 2.

[0047] As shown, the template **300** includes an element for each of the different types of items (e.g., start, condition, action, stop) included in a multi-condition, multi-action workflow being requested in a software application. For example, the template **300** includes a start element **302** that corresponds to the workflow start event **202** depicted in FIG. 2; a transaction rule evaluation element **304** that corresponds to the different conditions **204**, **220**, **234** depicted in FIG. 2; a send for approval element **306** that correspond to the different actions **206**, **234**, **236**, **242**, **246** depicted

in FIG. 2; and a stop element **308** that corresponds to the different stop actions (e.g., depicted as **208, 240, 244, 248**) depicted in FIG. 2.

[0048] The template **300** may also include implicit information that must be included in every process model object generated with the template **300**. For example, the implicit information may include one or more nodes that are not present in the requested multi-condition, multi-action workflow, such as an auto approval path (as illustrated by arrow extending from transaction rule evaluation element **304** to the stop element **308**) for instances in which a transaction does not satisfy any of conditions **204, 220, 234** depicted in FIG. 2. Alternatively, or additionally, the implicit information may include data associated with one or more sub-processes that are required to perform a particular task that may not be relevant to the multi-condition, multi-action workflow being requested in the software application.

[0049] As will now be discussed in more detail, user-provided information associated with the multi-condition, multi-action workflow being requested in the software application may be superimposed (e.g., merged) with the implicit information associated with the template **300** to dynamically generate a process model object for the requested multi-condition, multi-action workflow. It should be appreciated that “user-provided information” may refer to any information provided by the user when configuring the multi-condition, multi-action workflow in the user interface of the software application. For example, “user-provided information” in the context of the multi-condition, multi-action workflow being configured in the user interface screen **200** in FIG. 2 may include “Request approval from . . .” in the actions **206, 236, 242, 246** and the “Invoice amount is . . .” in the conditions **204, 220, 234**.

Example Process Model Object Dynamically Generated for a Multi-Condition, Multi-Action Workflow

[0050] FIG. 4 is an illustration of a process model object **400** dynamically generated for a multi-condition, multi-action workflow of a first type (e.g., approval workflow) according to some embodiments of the present disclosure. The process model object **400** may be dynamically generated by superimposing user-provided information associated with the multi-condition, multi-action workflow being requested and implicit information associated with a template for generating process model objects for multi-condition, multi-action workflows of the first type. For simplicity, the process model object **400** will be discussed in the context of the multi-condition, multi-action workflow illustrated in FIG. 2 and the template **300** for generating process model objects illustrated in FIG. 3.

[0051] The process model object **400** may include a start element **402** that corresponds to the start element **302** depicted in FIG. 3; a transaction rule evaluation element **404** that corresponds to the transaction rule evaluation element **304** depicted in FIG. 3 as well as the different conditions **204, 22, 234** depicted in FIG. 4; a plurality of action elements **406, 408, 410, 412** that correspond to the different actions **206, 234, 236, 242, 246** depicted in FIG. 2; and a stop element **414** that corresponds to the stop element **308** element depicted in FIG. 3 and the different stop actions (e.g., depicted as **208, 240, 244, 248**) depicted in FIG. 2.

[0052] In some embodiments, the transaction rule evaluation element **404** may include logic for evaluating the different conditions in the requested multi-condition, multi-action workflow to determine which particular action elements **406, 408, 410, 412** of the process model object **400** needs to be performed. For instance, in some embodiments, the transaction rule evaluation element **404** may include one or more decision model objects (not shown) that include the different conditions that need to be evaluated in order to determine which action elements needs to be executed. Furthermore, each of the action elements **406, 408, 410, 412** may include logic needed to perform the respective action.

[0053] It should be appreciated that each of the action elements **406, 408, 410, 412** may correspond to a different action included in the requested multi-condition, multi-action workflow (such as the multi-condition, multi-action workflow illustrated in FIG. 2). For example, the first action element

406 may correspond to the first action **206** that is to be performed based on evaluation of the first condition **204** included in the multi-condition, multi-action workflow being requested in the software application. The second action element **408** may correspond to the second action **236** in that is to be performed based on evaluation of the second condition **220** included in the multi-condition, multi-action workflow being requested in the software application. The third action element **410** may correspond to the third action **242** in that is to be performed based on evaluation of the third condition **234** included in the multi-condition, multi-action workflow. The fourth action element **412** may correspond to a fourth action (e.g., action **246** in FIG. 2) that is also to be performed based on evaluation of the third condition **234**.

Example Structure of Dynamically Generated Process Model Object for a Multi-Condition, Multi-Action Workflow

[0054] FIG. 5 illustrates a structure **500** (e.g., skeleton, tree) of a dynamically generated process model object (such as the process model object **400** illustrated in FIG. 4) according to some embodiments of the present disclosure. As shown, the structure **500** includes a plurality of nodes indicating a sequence of events to be performed based, at least in part, on the multiple conditions and multiple actions included in a requested multi-condition, multi-action workflow (such as the multi-condition, multi-action workflow illustrated in FIG. 2). The plurality of nodes includes a start node **502**, an end node **504**, a first condition node **506**, a second condition node **508**, a third condition node **510**, a first action node **512**, a second action node **514**, a third action node **516**, and a fourth action node **518**.

[0055] In some embodiments, the structure **500** may include information that can be used to determine connectivity with one or more other nodes of the structure. For instance, the structure **500** may include an event identifier for each of the plurality of nodes. The event identifier may indicate what type of event (e.g., start, rule evaluation, request for approval, end) in the sequence of events is represented by the respective node. Furthermore, the structure **500** may include a list of child nodes associated with a respective node of the structure **500**. For example, the second condition node **508** may include two child nodes, namely third condition node **510** and second action node **514**. Also, it should be appreciated that the structure **500** does not include the user-provided information for each of the condition nodes **506**, **508**, **510** and action nodes **512**, **514**, **516**, and **518**.

[0056] In some embodiments, the structure **500** may be represented as an adjacency vector that can be stored on a database. For example, the adjacency vector may specify the connectivity of the plurality of nodes of the structure **500** for the dynamically generated process model object. For instance, the adjacency vector may, in some instances, include the information (e.g., event identifier, child nodes, etc.) for each of the different nodes of the structure **500**.

[0057] In alternative embodiments, the structure **500** may be stored in the database as a data structure (e.g., a tree) that includes parent identifiers for each of the nodes. In this manner, the connectivity of the different nodes of the structure **500** can be determined based, at least in part, on the link between a respective node and its parent identifier (that is, a parent node of the respective node). With this particular data structure (e.g., a tree), the parent identifiers may be stored in a single row in the database. In this manner, the structure **500** (e.g., the row of parent identifiers) may be extracted from the database in a single search query.

Example Method for Dynamically Generating a Process Model Object for a Multi-Condition, Multi-Action Workflow

[0058] FIG. 6 depicts example operations **600** related to dynamically generating a process model object for a multi-condition, multi-action workflow requested in a software application for configuring workflows according to some embodiments of the present disclosure. For example, operations **600** may be performed by one or more components described above with respect to computing environment **100** of FIG. 1.

[0059] Operation **602** includes obtaining a request for an initial workflow (such as the multi-

condition, multi-action workflow illustrated in FIG. 2) including multiple conditions and multiple actions. Furthermore, the request may include user-provided information (e.g., taskName, email, etc.) for one or more of the conditions and one or more of the actions. In some embodiments, the request may be provided via a user-interface associated with a software application for generating workflows.

[0060] Operation **604** includes mapping the initial workflow to a template for generating process model objects for multi-condition, multi-action workflows. The template may include a single condition block to represent the multiple conditions and a single action block to represent the multiple actions. For instance, each of the multiple conditions included in the initial workflow requested at operation **602** may be matched to the single condition block of the template. In addition, each of the multiple actions included in the initial workflow requested at operation **602** may be matched to the single action block of the template.

[0061] Operation **606** includes extracting the user-provided information from the request for the initial workflow at operation **602**. For instance, the user-provided information included for each of the multiple conditions and multiple actions may be extracted from the request obtained at operation **602**. In some embodiments, the extracted user-provided information may be stored on the data store.

[0062] Operation **608** includes dynamically generating a first process model object of the initial complex workflow based, at least in part, on the user-provided information extracted at operation **606** and implicit information associated with the template to which the initial workflow requested at operation **602** is mapped at operation **604**. For instance, the extracted user-provided information may be superimposed (e.g., merged) with the implicit information associated with the template to dynamically generate the process model object.

[0063] Operation **610** includes generating a unique structure (e.g., skeleton, tree) of the process model object dynamically generated at operation **608**. The unique structure (such as the structure **500** illustrated in FIG. 5) may include a plurality of nodes, and each of the nodes may correspond to a respective event (e.g., start event, transaction rule evaluation event, request for approval event, end event) included in a sequence of events to be performed based, at least in part, on the multiple conditions and multiple actions included in the workflow requested at operation **602**.

[0064] Operation **612** includes storing data indicative of the structure of the process model object for the initial workflow on a database. In some embodiments, the data indicative of the structure of the process model object may be represented as an adjacency vector specifying the connectivity between the nodes that make up the structure. Furthermore, the adjacency vector may exclude the user-provided information included in the request obtained at operation **602**. In this manner, the adjacency vector may be unaffected by changes to properties of the process model object dynamically generated at operation **608** and therefore may represent the core structure of the process model object.

[0065] In some embodiments, storing the structure on the database may include determining whether an instance of the data indicative of the structure of the process model object is already stored on the database. For example, the database may be queried to determine whether an instance of the data (e.g., adjacency vector) is already stored on the database. If, based on the querying, it is determined that there is not an instance of the data (e.g., adjacency vector) already stored on the database, then the data (e.g., adjacency vector) may be stored in the database. Furthermore, in some embodiments, the adjacency vector may be converted to a unique hash value that is then stored on the database.

[0066] The operations **600** may further include reusing the structure of the process model object for an additional multi-condition, multi-action workflow requested (e.g., via the user-interface of the software application). In this manner, the operations **600** may allow process model objects, specifically the structure thereof that is stored on the database, to be reused for subsequent requests for multi-condition, multi-action workflows having the same structure (that is, the same sequence

of events based, at least in part, on the multiple conditions and multiple actions specified for subsequent workflows). In some embodiments, operations **602**, **604**, **606**, and **608** may be repeated for the additional multi-condition, multi-action workflow. More specifically, the structure of a process model object for the additional multi-condition, multi-action workflow may be generated and compared against the database. Then, when it is determined that the structure of the process model object for the additional multi-condition, multi-action workflow matches the structure of the process model object for the initial multi-condition, multi-action workflow requested at operation **602**, the additional multi-condition, multi-action workflow may be generated using the structure of the process model object for the initial multi-condition, multi-action workflow requested at operation **602**. Furthermore, since the structure of the process model object for the additional multi-condition, multi-action workflow matches the structure of the process model object dynamically generated for the initial multi-condition, multi-action workflow requested at operation **602**, the structure of the process model object for the additional workflow may be discarded. In this manner, the disclosed operations **600** prevent multiple instances of the process model object, specifically the structure thereof, being stored on the database.

Example Computing Systems

[0067] FIG. 7A illustrates an example computing system **700** with which embodiments of the disclosure related to automated workflow configuration assistance may be implemented. For example, the computing system **700** may be representative of server **120** of FIG. 1.

[0068] The computing system **700** includes a central processing unit (CPU) **702**, one or more I/O device interfaces **704** that may allow for the connection of various I/O devices **704** (e.g., keyboards, displays, mouse devices, pen input, etc.) to the computing system **700**, a network interface **706**, a memory **708**, and an interconnect **712**. It is contemplated that one or more components of the computing system **700** may be located remotely and accessed via a network **710**. It is further contemplated that one or more components of the computing system **700** may include physical components or virtualized components.

[0069] The CPU **702** may retrieve and execute programming instructions stored in the memory **708**. Similarly, the CPU **702** may retrieve and store application data residing in the memory **708**. The interconnect **712** transmits programming instructions and application data, among the CPU **702**, the I/O device interface **704**, the network interface **706**, the memory **708**. The CPU **702** is included to be representative of a single CPU, multiple CPUs, a single CPU having multiple processing cores, and other arrangements.

[0070] Additionally, the memory **708** is included to be representative of a random access memory or the like. In some embodiments, the memory **708** may include a disk drive, solid state drive, or a collection of storage devices distributed across multiple storage systems. Although shown as a single unit, the memory **708** may be a combination of fixed and/or removable storage devices, such as fixed disc drives, removable memory cards or optical storage, network attached storage (NAS), or a storage area-network (SAN).

[0071] As shown, the memory **708** includes application **714**, workflow processing engine **716**, and data store **720** including data indicative of unique structures for different process model objects **722**, which may be representative of the application **122**, the workflow processing engine **124**, the data store **140**, and the data **142** indicative of unique structures for process model objects of FIG. 1.

[0072] FIG. 6B illustrates an example computing system **750** with which embodiments of the system related to automatically recommending items for selection with a software application through machine learning may be implemented. For example, the computing system **750** may be representative of client **130** of FIG. 1.

[0073] The computing system **750** includes a central processing unit (CPU) **752**, one or more I/O device interfaces **754** that may allow for the connection of various I/O devices **754** (e.g., keyboards, displays, mouse devices, pen input, etc.) to the computing system **750**, a network interface **756**, a memory **758**, and an interconnect **760**. It is contemplated that one or more

components of the computing system **750** may be located remotely and accessed via a network **762**. It is further contemplated that one or more components of the computing system **750** may include physical components or virtualized components.

[0074] The CPU **752** may retrieve and execute programming instructions stored in the memory **758**. Similarly, the CPU **752** may retrieve and store application data residing in the memory **758**. The interconnect **760** transmits programming instructions and application data, among the CPU **752**, the I/O device interface **754**, the network interface **756**, the memory **758**. The CPU **752** is included to be representative of a single CPU, multiple CPUs, a single CPU having multiple processing cores, and other arrangements.

[0075] Additionally, the memory **758** is included to be representative of a random access memory or the like. In some embodiments, the memory **758** may include a disk drive, solid state drive, or a collection of storage devices distributed across multiple storage systems. Although shown as a single unit, the memory **658** may be a combination of fixed and/or removable storage devices, such as fixed disc drives, removable memory cards or optical storage, network attached storage (NAS), or a storage area-network (SAN).

[0076] As shown, the memory **758** may include an application **764**, such as a user-side application (e.g., comprising a user interface) discussed above with respect to the client **130** of FIG. **1**.

Additional Considerations

[0077] The preceding description provides examples, and is not limiting of the scope, applicability, or embodiments set forth in the claims. Changes may be made in the function and arrangement of elements discussed without departing from the scope of the disclosure. Various examples may omit, substitute, or add various procedures or components as appropriate. For instance, the methods described may be performed in an order different from that described, and various steps may be added, omitted, or combined. Also, features described with respect to some examples may be combined in some other examples. For example, an apparatus may be implemented or a method may be practiced using any number of the aspects set forth herein. In addition, the scope of the disclosure is intended to cover such an apparatus or method that is practiced using other structure, functionality, or structure and functionality in addition to, or other than, the various aspects of the disclosure set forth herein. It should be understood that any aspect of the disclosure disclosed herein may be embodied by one or more elements of a claim.

[0078] The preceding description is provided to enable any person skilled in the art to practice the various embodiments described herein. Various modifications to these embodiments will be readily apparent to those skilled in the art, and the generic principles defined herein may be applied to other embodiments. For example, changes may be made in the function and arrangement of elements discussed without departing from the scope of the disclosure. Various examples may omit, substitute, or add various procedures or components as appropriate. Also, features described with respect to some examples may be combined in some other examples. For example, an apparatus may be implemented or a method may be practiced using any number of the aspects set forth herein. In addition, the scope of the disclosure is intended to cover such an apparatus or method that is practiced using other structure, functionality, or structure and functionality in addition to, or other than, the various aspects of the disclosure set forth herein. It should be understood that any aspect of the disclosure disclosed herein may be embodied by one or more elements of a claim.

[0079] As used herein, a phrase referring to “at least one of” a list of items refers to any combination of those items, including single members. As an example, “at least one of: a, b, or c” is intended to cover a, b, c, a-b, a-c, b-c, and a-b-c, as well as any combination with multiples of the same element (e.g., a-a, a-a-a, a-a-b, a-a-c, a-b-b, a-c-c, b-b, b-b-b, b-b-c, c-c, and c-c-c or any other ordering of a, b, and c).

[0080] As used herein, the term “determining” encompasses a wide variety of actions. For example, “determining” may include calculating, computing, processing, deriving, investigating, looking up (e.g., looking up in a table, a database or another data structure), ascertaining and other operations.

Also, “determining” may include receiving (e.g., receiving information), accessing (e.g., accessing data in a memory) and other operations. Also, “determining” may include resolving, selecting, choosing, establishing and other operations.

[0081] The methods disclosed herein comprise one or more steps or actions for achieving the methods. The method steps and/or actions may be interchanged with one another without departing from the scope of the claims. In other words, unless a specific order of steps or actions is specified, the order and/or use of specific steps and/or actions may be modified without departing from the scope of the claims. Further, the various operations of methods described above may be performed by any suitable means capable of performing the corresponding functions. The means may include various hardware and/or software component(s) and/or module(s), including, but not limited to a circuit, an application specific integrated circuit (ASIC), or processor. Generally, where there are operations illustrated in figures, those operations may have corresponding counterpart means-plus-function components with similar numbering.

[0082] The various illustrative logical blocks, modules and circuits described in connection with the present disclosure may be implemented or performed with a general purpose processor, a digital signal processor (DSP), an application specific integrated circuit (ASIC), a field programmable gate array (FPGA) or other programmable logic device (PLD), discrete gate or transistor logic, discrete hardware components, or any combination thereof designed to perform the functions described herein. A general-purpose processor may be a microprocessor, but in the alternative, the processor may be any commercially available processor, controller, microcontroller, or state machine. A processor may also be implemented as a combination of computing devices, e.g., a combination of a DSP and a microprocessor, a plurality of microprocessors, one or more microprocessors in conjunction with a DSP core, or any other such configuration.

[0083] A processing system may be implemented with a bus architecture. The bus may include any number of interconnecting buses and bridges depending on the specific application of the processing system and the overall design constraints. The bus may link together various circuits including a processor, machine-readable media, and input/output devices, among others. A user interface (e.g., keypad, display, mouse, joystick, etc.) may also be connected to the bus. The bus may also link various other circuits such as timing sources, peripherals, voltage regulators, power management circuits, and other types of circuits, which are well known in the art, and therefore, will not be described any further. The processor may be implemented with one or more general-purpose and/or special-purpose processors. Examples include microprocessors, microcontrollers, DSP processors, and other circuitry that can execute software. Those skilled in the art will recognize how best to implement the described functionality for the processing system depending on the particular application and the overall design constraints imposed on the overall system.

[0084] If implemented in software, the functions may be stored or transmitted over as one or more instructions or code on a computer-readable medium. Software shall be construed broadly to mean instructions, data, or any combination thereof, whether referred to as software, firmware, middleware, microcode, hardware description language, or otherwise. Computer-readable media include both computer storage media and communication media, such as any medium that facilitates transfer of a computer program from one place to another. The processor may be responsible for managing the bus and general processing, including the execution of software modules stored on the computer-readable storage media. A computer-readable storage medium may be coupled to a processor such that the processor can read information from, and write information to, the storage medium. In the alternative, the storage medium may be integral to the processor. By way of example, the computer-readable media may include a transmission line, a carrier wave modulated by data, and/or a computer readable storage medium with instructions stored thereon separate from the wireless node, all of which may be accessed by the processor through the bus interface. Alternatively, or in addition, the computer-readable media, or any portion thereof, may be integrated into the processor, such as the case may be with cache and/or general register files.

Examples of machine-readable storage media may include, by way of example, RAM (Random Access Memory), flash memory, ROM (Read Only Memory), PROM (Programmable Read-Only Memory), EPROM (Erasable Programmable Read-Only Memory), EEPROM (Electrically Erasable Programmable Read-Only Memory), registers, magnetic disks, optical disks, hard drives, or any other suitable storage medium, or any combination thereof. The machine-readable media may be embodied in a computer-program product.

[0085] A software module may comprise a single instruction, or many instructions, and may be distributed over several different code segments, among different programs, and across multiple storage media. The computer-readable media may comprise a number of software modules. The software modules include instructions that, when executed by an apparatus such as a processor, cause the processing system to perform various functions. The software modules may include a transmission module and a receiving module. Each software module may reside in a single storage device or be distributed across multiple storage devices. By way of example, a software module may be loaded into RAM from a hard drive when a triggering event occurs. During execution of the software module, the processor may load some of the instructions into cache to increase access speed. One or more cache lines may then be loaded into a general register file for execution by the processor. When referring to the functionality of a software module, it will be understood that such functionality is implemented by the processor when executing instructions from that software module.

[0086] The following claims are not intended to be limited to the embodiments shown herein, but are to be accorded the full scope consistent with the language of the claims. Within a claim, reference to an element in the singular is not intended to mean “one and only one” unless specifically so stated, but rather “one or more.” Unless specifically stated otherwise, the term “some” refers to one or more. No claim element is to be construed under the provisions of 35 U.S.C. § 112(f) unless the element is expressly recited using the phrase “means for” or, in the case of a method claim, the element is recited using the phrase “step for.” All structural and functional equivalents to the elements of the various aspects described throughout this disclosure that are known or later come to be known to those of ordinary skill in the art are expressly incorporated herein by reference and are intended to be encompassed by the claims. Moreover, nothing disclosed herein is intended to be dedicated to the public regardless of whether such disclosure is explicitly recited in the claims.

Claims

1. A method for dynamically generating process model objects for workflows, the method comprising: obtaining a request from a user of a software application for configuring workflows, the request being for an initial workflow including multiple conditions and multiple actions, the request including user-provided information for one or more of the multiple conditions and one or more of the multiple actions; mapping the initial workflow to a template for generating process model objects for workflows, the template comprising a single condition block to represent the multiple conditions and a single action block to represent the multiple actions; extracting the user-provided information from the request; and dynamically generating a process model object for the initial workflow based, at least in part, on the extracted user-provided information and information associated with the template.
2. The method of claim 1, wherein the information associated with the template comprises implicit information for one or more sub-processes associated with the single condition block or one or more sub-processes associated with the single action block.
3. The method of claim 1, further comprising: generating a structure of the process model object for the initial workflow, the structure including a plurality of nodes, each of the nodes corresponding to a respective event included in a sequence of events to be performed based, at least in part, on the

multiple conditions and the multiple actions included in the request for the workflow; and storing data indicative of the structure on a database.

4. The method of claim 3, wherein the data indicative of the structure comprises an adjacency vector specifying connectivity between the plurality of nodes of the structure.

5. The method of claim 4, wherein the storing comprises: determining an instance of the adjacency vector is not already stored on the database; and in response to the determining, storing the adjacency vector on the database.

6. The method of claim 5, wherein the storing further comprises: converting the adjacency vector to a unique hash value; and storing the unique hash value on the database.

7. The method of claim 3, further comprising: obtaining a request for an additional workflow including multiple conditions and multiple actions; reusing the structure of the process model object for the initial workflow to generate the additional workflow.

8. The method of claim 7, further comprising: generating a structure of a process model object for the additional workflow; determining the structure of the process model object for the additional workflow matches the structure of the process model object for the initial workflow; and in response to the determining, reusing the structure of the process model object for the initial workflow to generate the additional workflow.

9. The method of claim 8, further comprising: discarding the structure of the process model object for the additional workflow.

10. The method of claim 1, wherein the process model object for the initial workflow comprises a serialized graph.

11. The method of claim 1, wherein obtaining the request for the initial workflow comprises obtaining the request via user-input provided via a graphical user interface associated with the software application.

12. A system comprising: a memory including computer executable instructions; and a processor configured to execute the computer executable instructions and cause the system to: obtain a request from a user of a software application for configuring workflows, the request being for an initial workflow including multiple conditions and multiple actions, the request including user-provided information for one or more of the multiple conditions and one or more of the multiple actions; map the initial workflow to a template for generating process model objects for workflows, the template comprising a single condition block to represent the multiple conditions and a single action block to represent the multiple actions; extract the user-provided information from the request; and dynamically generate a process model object for the initial workflow based, at least in part, on the extracted user-provided information and information associated with the template.

13. The system of claim 12, wherein the information associated with the template comprises implicit information for one or more sub-processes associated with the single condition block or one or more sub-processes associated with the single action block.

14. The system of claim 12, wherein the processor is configured to execute the computer executable instructions and further cause the system to: generate a structure of the process model object for the initial workflow, the structure including a plurality of nodes, each of the nodes corresponding to a respective event included in a sequence of events to be performed based, at least in part, on the multiple conditions and the multiple actions included in the request for the workflow; and store data indicative of the structure on a database.

15. The system of claim 14, wherein the data indicative of the structure comprises an adjacency vector specifying connectivity between the plurality of nodes of the structure.

16. The system of claim 15, wherein to store the adjacency vector, the processor is configured to execute the computer executable instructions to cause the system to: determine an instance of the adjacency vector is not already stored on the database; and in response to the determining, store the adjacency vector on the database.

17. The system of claim 14, wherein the processor is configured to execute the computer

executable instructions and further cause the system to: obtain a request for an additional workflow including multiple conditions and multiple actions; and reuse the structure of the process model object for the initial workflow to generate the additional workflow.

18. The system of claim 17, wherein the processor is configured to execute the computer executable instructions and further cause the system to: generate a structure of a process model object for the additional workflow; determine the structure of the process model object for the additional workflow matches the structure of the process model object for the initial workflow; and in response to the determining, reuse the structure of the process model object for the initial workflow to generate the additional workflow.

19. The system of claim 18, wherein the processor is configured to execute the computer executable instructions and further cause the system to: discard the structure of the process model object for the additional workflow.

20. A non-transitory computer-readable medium comprising instructions to be executed in a computer system to dynamically generate complex workflows, wherein the instructions when executed in the computer system cause the computer system to: obtain a request from a user of a software application for configuring workflows, the request being for an initial workflow including multiple conditions and multiple actions, the request including user-provided information for one or more of the multiple conditions and one or more of the multiple actions; map the initial workflow to a template for generating process model objects for workflows, the template comprising a single condition block to represent the multiple conditions and a single action block to represent the multiple actions; extract the user-provided information from the request; and dynamically generate a process model object for the initial workflow based, at least in part, on the extracted user-provided information and information associated with the template.
